

agree to put their home on the market, and the agent, when they decide who will run the sales campaign, and is based on recent sales and market conditions.

- **Offers rejected by the vendor**

If any offers are put forward before auction day but are knocked back by the vendor, the agent must adjust the advertised price to show that the price expectations have risen.

Help the agent to help you

For all the fretful years saving for the deposit, it's often the first face-to-face dealing with agents that scares first home buyers the most, and it shouldn't. Sure, they represent the seller, but don't treat them as a foe. Auctioneer Stuart Benson says that talking to the agent 'will keep you abreast of the vendor's expectations and where the goalposts may have been moved to, and so on auction day you know what that may look like'. He says:

I cannot state it enough – communication is the key. The agent's head is spinning as well. They have got the vendor's expectations to measure and hopefully meet, they have different buyers from different walks of life, different emotional content, investors going up against first home buyers, and you can fade into the background if you have not made your intentions known in the lead-up.

Ask the agent for comparable sales, which have helped them to decide on the property's price with their vendor, but also do your own research. Having a confident, evidence-based handle on the price you're willing to pay will improve negotiations, when you and the agent finally sit across the table and start serious talks. Agent Samantha McCarthy of Hocking Stuart sells frequently to first home buyers, and says that due to inexperience and nerves they are often unsure of how much information they should give away, such as budget, in the first meeting with an agent. '[When] we ask them questions ... they don't know if they should answer them in any particular way. If they are upfront, then we can help them a lot better,' she says.